together to find solutions to some of the most challenging issues of our times. From bringing Covid-19 vaccines to all corners of the world and sharing essential medicines to climate action initiatives such as the One Sun One World One Grid initiative and Infrastructure for Resilient Island States (IRIS) announced at the COP26 summit in Glasgow last year, the two countries have worked in close cooperation.

Truss already sees India as an 'economic powerhouse', a reliable partner and a principled, independent voice in multilateral fora. Leaders of the two mature democracies have engaged constructively even on subjects they differ on. For example, on Ukraine, Truss well understands India's point of view, though she herself is committed to punitive measures against Russia and material support to Ukraine. Similarly, India will continue to press for the return of fugitives long harboured in the UK and the curbing of anti-India elements operating from its territory.

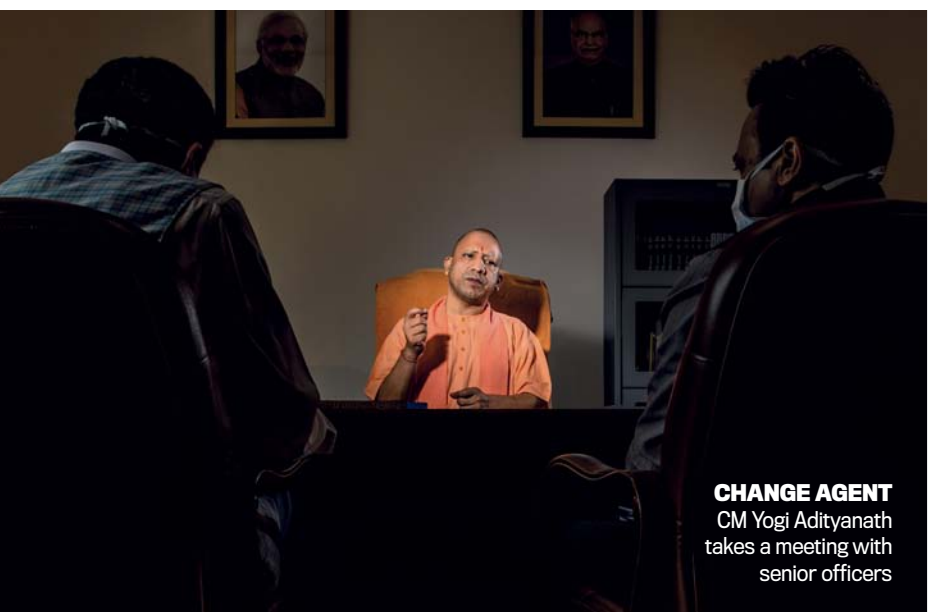
Overall, in the Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Office (FCDO) and across Whitehall, and in political circles and the media, there is tremendous enthusiasm for strengthening India-UK ties. There is every reason to expect that Truss's tenure will be marked by the expansion of India-UK cooperation—both in bilateral terms and for a better world. ■

The writer recently retired as India High Commissioner to the UK

UTTAR PRADESH

YOGI'S NEW INNER CIRCLE

By Prashant Srivastava



CHANGE AGENT CM Yogi Adityanath takes a meeting with senior officers

BANDEEP SINGH

In recent years, the Uttar Pradesh bureaucracy had developed an image of being controlled by a few officers with a huge, even disproportionate, role in major decisions. Awanish Awasthi, a 1987 batch IAS officer, and his 1988 batch compeer Navneet Sehgal were the stars—two of chief minister Yogi Adityanath's most trusted aides, entrusted with the keys to the kingdom. Suddenly last week, everything changed. Awasthi, additional chief secretary (ACS) for home, vigilance and a host of other key departments, had his retirement date coming up on August 31, but the buzz was he would get an extension. Not only did that not happen, just hours after his retirement, even ACS Sehgal, widely seen as the CM's troubleshooter, was shunted out from the high-profile information and MSME departments to the modest sports department. And it didn't end there: it was a transfer blitz the likes of which had not been seen in UP since Mayawati's days as CM. Besides Sehgal, 15 other senior IAS officers were transferred—including Amit Mohan Prasad (ACS health) and Aradhna Shukla (ACS secondary education). UP's "most powerful officer" will now be the 1995-batch IAS officer Sanjay Prasad, who has been given additional charge of home and information along with his current post, that of principal secretary to the CM.

Prasad, who hails from Bihar, has had a long stint in UP. In his early years (1999-2001), he served as district magistrate (DM) in a number of places, including Faizabad and Agra, and was also chief development officer of Gorakhpur. Sources in the CM's office describe Prasad as Yogi's "blue-eyed boy". "After S.P. Goyal, additional chief secretary to the CM, if Adityanath trusts anybody, it's Prasad. Any data-related document to be sent to the CM first goes past Prasad," says the source. Yogi